shaped in large part by its foreign interactions. It is therefore crucial that India understands the world better.

India also increasingly matters to the rest of the world. It is the world's most populous country; indeed, it is the most populous country in human history. India is, as of 2024, the fifth-largest economy by gross domestic product (GDP) and will soon be the world's third largest. It has the second-largest number of people online and is expected to have the world's largest working-age population. India is also third in energy and electricity consumption and greenhouse gas emissions. It boasts the largest active-duty military, it has in recent years been the third- or fourth-largest military spender, and it possesses nuclear weapons.[2] India will therefore play a critical role in determining the future of the international order, the global economy, the digital realm, and the earth's climate. The rest of the world must understand India better.

Why This Book

The understanding of India's engagements with the world—past, present, and future—remains limited. There is a rich body of literature on many aspects of India's foreign policy: many significant works are included in the references at the end of this book. They encompass diplomatic, military, and political histories, numerous personal memoirs, polemical works and essays, intellectual and cultural studies, and edited volumes. Most focus on specific relationships, periods, individuals, or themes. This book draws on various strands of existing scholarship and other materials to tell a concise history of India and the world, one that helps provide important context and a framework for thinking about its national objectives and global priorities today. It tells the story of an India that witnessed complex discussions about its place in international affairs, made tough decisions, endured daunting challenges, and played a more active global role than is often understood. In doing so, this volume also attempts to channel an inherently Indian perspective on some issues, overturn some conventional wisdom, and contribute to India's strategic vocabulary.